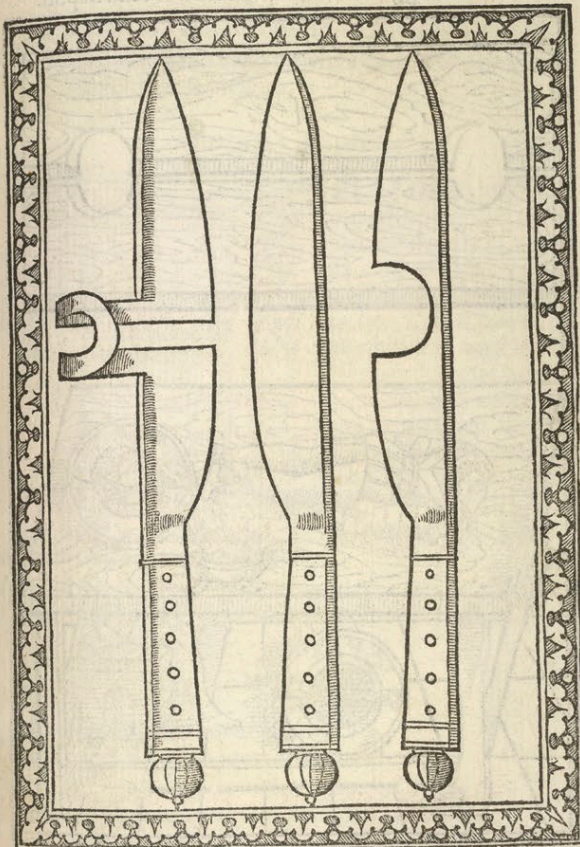


Hartumim. of Witchcraft. Cap.34.

To thrust a knife through your arme, and to
cut halfe your nose asunder, &c.



The middlemost
knife is to
serue for
shew; the
other two
be the
knives of
deuise.

To be readie in the vse and perfect in the practise of these
knives here portrayed, see page 347. and 348.

◀ Illusions with bodkins and knives

In this illustration from *The Discoverie of Witchcraft*, Scot shows how substituting knives for blades with sections removed, or using bodkins with the points removed, can trick the viewer into thinking that a wound has been inflicted.

doubt on the effectiveness of torture, the search for witches' marks, and the water test (see p.181), all of which played a key role in securing evidence for witchcraft convictions.

In the eyes of the law

Although those in favor of witch trials fought back fiercely—including James I of England in his *Daemonologie* (1597)—gradually the weight of opinion turned against the notion that witchcraft was real. In France, a 1682 law of Louis XIV categorized witchcraft as a form of fraud, rather than a question of demonic pacts. Half a century later, the Witchcraft Act of 1736 in Great Britain abolished witchcraft as a crime and replaced it with a lesser offense and punishment: anyone found guilty of the deceit involved in inducing people to believe in fortune-telling or other occult practices was sentenced to a year's imprisonment.

Witch trials continued on a small scale, and witchcraft as a crime was only removed from the statute book in Denmark in 1866. However, the last woman accused of witchcraft who underwent the death penalty in Europe in fact received the sentence for poisoning rather than sorcery or heresy at her trial in 1782.

▼ Witches in history

This woodcut of Macbeth and Banquo meeting three witches on a heath is from *Holinshed's Chronicles*, which Shakespeare drew on for his plays. The artist depicts the characters as lords and ladies rather than stereotyping the witches as ugly hags brewing potions.

(1584), in which he cataloged and meticulously debunked a wide range of magical techniques. Most magic, he concluded, was a matter of trickery perpetrated on the gullible, and most witchcraft accusations were directed at poor women ill-equipped to defend themselves. Like Weyer, he believed that many of the accused suffered from delusions.

Critics of the trial process

Other witchcraft disbelievers took firmer aim at the trial process itself, claiming that the procedures used to identify witches were unsound. In Germany, Friedrich Spee's book on witch trials entitled *Cautio criminalis* (1631) denounced the excessive religious zeal and exaggerated procedures that always favored a guilty verdict. Other skeptics cast

